

Rhetoric vs Reality: A Countermapping Project

- [Introduction](#)
- [Mapping Data: My Process](#)
- [Analysis](#)
- [Conclusion](#)
- [Notes](#)
- [Kamehameha Schools' Data Sources](#)

Introduction:

This project seeks to explore how to use countermapping as a tool of accountability.

In Hawai'i, cultural rhetoric has become a marketing tool for community and commercial organizations alike. This is particularly profuse in the non-profit realm. Invoking Hawaiian values in mission statements, purpose-driven programming descriptions, and financial reporting seems to be a standard in the justification of funding eligibility. Yet the language and imagery used often fails to communicate the material reality of what these organizations accomplish in the communities they are purported to support and serve.

Kamehameha Schools is one of the largest and wealthiest cultural institutions and private landowners in Hawai'i, with an endowed trust valued at \$15.2 billion. They are prolific in their use of cultural rhetoric in highlighting the endeavors that carry out their [mission](#) to "fulfill Ke Ali'i Pauahi's vision of empowering Native Hawaiians in perpetuity by improving the well-being of our people through education.". Their website, program descriptions, annual reports, etc. are steeped with Hawaiian language and imagery in the self-advertisement of their role as stewards of culture, land, and community. In this way, as a funding source for many of the smaller non-profits that serve Native Hawaiian communities, they shape the expectation of how Hawaiian rhetoric is used in representing cultural identity.

Yet the answer to the question of whether they accomplish what they advertise in their claims of cultural/land/community stewardship and the promise of a better future for Hawai'i is not obvious. As a legacy institution, how much of what they say they do is verifiable and accountable to the language they invoke and the imagery they forefront?

A central focus through this exploration was whether it was possible to map monetary investments of Kamehameha Schools using publicly available financial data and create a visual representation of their actual community investment.

Mapping Data: My Process

Kamehameha Schools' Maps: I began with looking at the maps Kamehameha Schools makes available on their website under the ['Āina Pauahi initiative](#). As part of their [2030 strategic plan](#), they consolidated land ownership into a single unified portfolio titled 'Āina Pauahi, and designated four categories of land use. Through ArcGis, they created an interactive map that makes these designations visible: [Agriculture](#), [Conservation](#), [Commercial](#), and [Education](#). In an

[enhanced view](#), you are also able to toggle through different layers of geographic distinction, such as state and county zoning, ahupua'a and moku designations, and various layers of weather patterns throughout the island chain.

My first question was how I might use their maps to show whether their financial investments reflected the stewardship claims they purport, particularly for agriculture and conservation lands. Could I overlay a monetary map on the land boundaries to reflect an alignment or misalignment between actual financial investment and claims of investment?

Kamehameha Schools Financial Data: To make sense of their financial claims, I sorted through annual reports, financial activities reports, consolidated finances reports, and Form 990 tax filings. This information was not readily organized or compiled, with many of the financial reports only findable through changing the year on the file name. As such, not all years were available. What I could find, I compiled and linked in the Data Sources list below.

For the sake of this project, I focused on the 2019-2020 fiscal year, which was the year referenced on their agriculture/conservation map website.

In their annual reports, rife with colorful infographics and pie charts, it was difficult to determine how they were categorizing their financial contributions for land management vs community stewardship, often combining agriculture and conservation totals, and failing to distinguish the difference between community investment and community education and engagement. Because of this, it was hard to know which infographic totals correlated to the totals listed in the more detailed financial reports. The financial categories were labelled differently and I did not have the time or expertise to quickly make sense of this disparity.

Kamehameha Schools' Contributions: Ultimately, I utilized the list of organizations donated to, included in Schedule I of the Form 990 tax filing for the 2019-2020 fiscal year. These were the (mostly) non-profit organizations that Kamehameha Schools invested in annually. To geocode these organizations and create coordinates for mapping, I exported their information from the Form 990 on ProPublica and into a spreadsheet and separated out the organization's name, street address, city, state, zip code, and contribution amount given to them. I also created a separate category to note which addresses were PO boxes vs. physical addresses. This dataset is available in the github repository listed in the Notes section below.

In ArcGis, I uploaded the dataset as a geocoded layer and allowed ArcGis to correlate the size of the point on the map with the contribution amount. Additionally, it color coded which points were physical addresses and which were PO boxes. This distinction did not end up being significant, since PO box addresses are common in Hawai'i, particularly for outer islands, and are most often situated in the same geographic location as the organization itself.

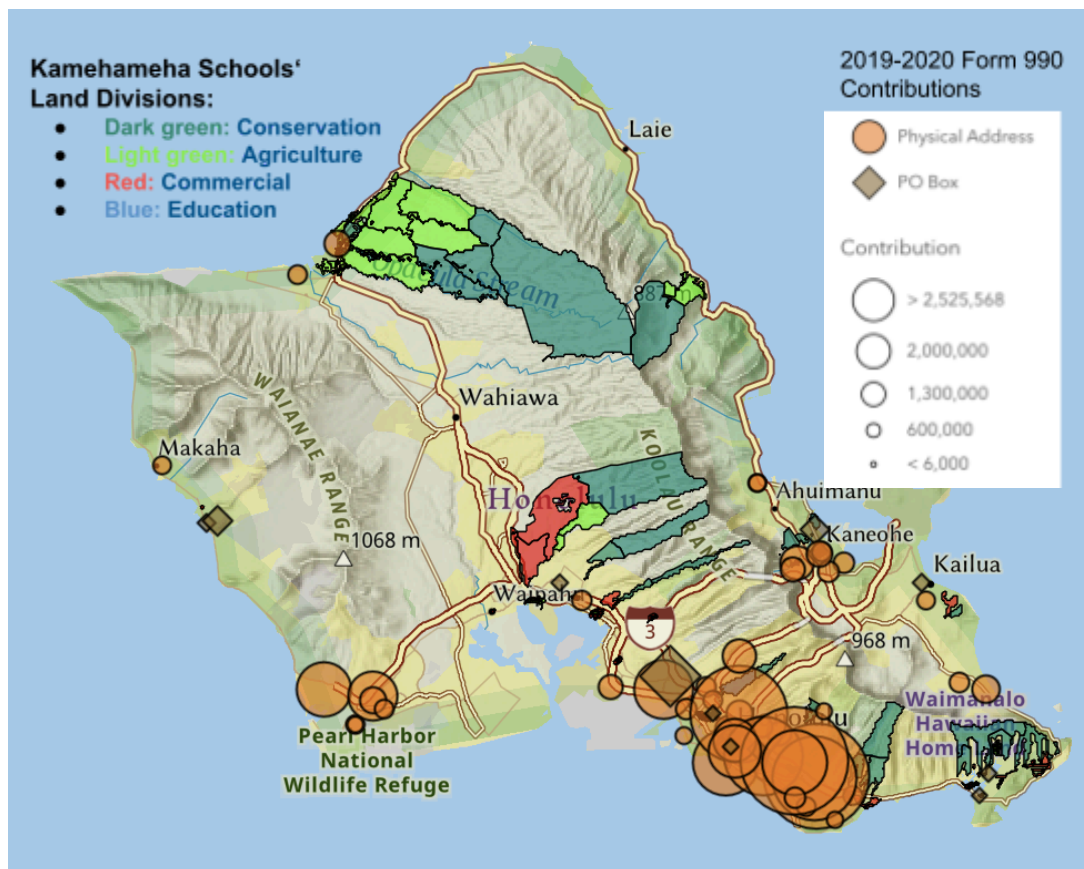


Image A: Arc-Gis map of O'ahu. National Geographic base layer + Kamehameha Schools' Land Divisions + 2019-2020 Form 990 Contributions

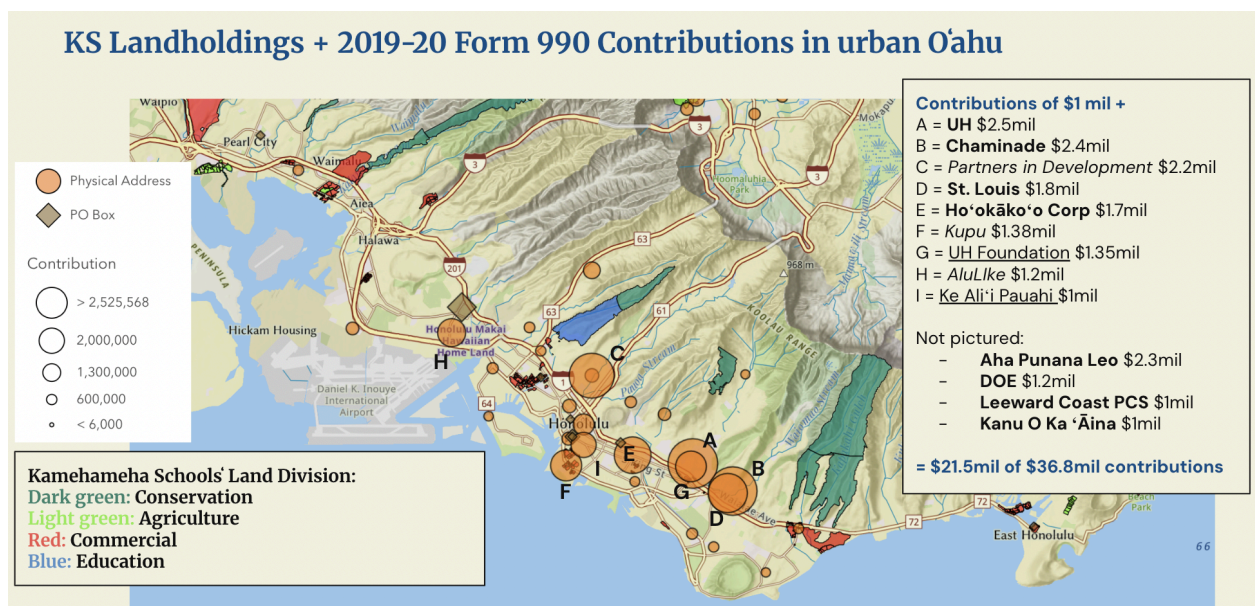


Image B: zoomed in map of Image A (southeast O'ahu); labelled are organizations who received \$1 million or more in contributions from Kamehameha Schools

Analysis

The snapshot above shows the organizations who were given one \$1 million or more during 2019-2020. The largest donations were primarily to educational organizations (bolded) - University of Hawai'i, Chaminade University, 'Aha Punana Leo, St. Louis High School, Ho'okāko'o Corporation, Department of Education, Leeward Coast Public Charter School, and Kanu O Ka 'Āina Charter School. Social and community organizations (italicized) donated to were Partner in Development, Kupu Hawai'i, and Alu Like. Lastly, fundraising organizations (underlined) for University of Hawai'i (UH Foundation) and Kamehameha Schools (Ke Ali'i Pauahi) were listed. Most of their offices were situated in the business and financial district of the capital city of Honolulu. These contributions make up about \$21.5 million of the \$36.8 million Kamehameha Schools donated to community organizations in 2019-2020.

While no substantiated claims can be made from this snapshot, it is easy to get a sense of the financial flow contained within this portion of Kamehameha Schools' fiscal spending for that year. The question I considered in this examination was whether these organizations represent the values Kamehameha Schools forefronts in their self-representation as purveyors of Hawaiian culture and education? I will leave it to each person to find truth in the conclusions that may be drawn here.

Conclusion

As such, can financial data be mapped to overlap in a meaningful way with the Kamehameha Schools land designations, particularly agriculture and conservation, and create a point of visual analysis? Given the constraints of this project - in time, knowledge, and resources - the methods I used does not provide this specifically, but it allowed me a glimpse into the possibility of how creating visual representations of financial flow for the sake of transparency and accountability can be accomplished.

With more time, being able to map contributions from more years could give a wider vantage point of who the organizations are that Kamehameha Schools consistently invests in. With more resources and specialized knowledge, translating financial statements into mappable points could give greater insight into fiscal spending trends. These are just some of the ways in which this project could help empower people to critically examine the institutions who are meant to serve and represent them.

Additionally, I think it's necessary, as a Native Hawaiian scholar examining a Native Hawaiian institution, to acknowledge that I do not seek to negate the good that Kamehameha Schools does and has done throughout Hawai'i - in education, in community support, and in providing opportunity for Native Hawaiians. They are a fixture and pillar of cultural revitalization and the financial contributions given to organizations doing significant work in local communities is not insignificant, as well as the educational opportunities that many Native Hawaiian families, mine included, have benefited from. Yet Kamehameha Schools, as with most institutions in Hawai'i, is chronically distant from the lived everyday realities of disenfranchised and dispossessed Native Hawaiians. How can an organization that speaks of serving the Hawaiian community have so

much while many in those very communities continue to have so little? Can mapping this disparity drive an awareness of how Hawaiian language and values are appropriated from within to serve a fiscal function rather than fuel movement towards greater sovereignty? Can it help to make more visible the cultural performativity that undermines collective movement yet continues to shape our islands through material investment and disinvestment? These questions become more and more necessary as Hawaiians fight to reclaim their sovereignty and rally against hegemonic domination, even as it surfaces from within.

Notes

- This project is the final product of a Spring 2026 countermapping course at American University in Washington D.C., as part of the Public Anthropology Master's program.
- For more information about this project, please contact Moanililia Miller at moanililia.miller@gmail.com
- Data for this project is available at <https://github.com/moanililiamiller-stack/countermapping>
- Other mapping projects related to conservation work and organizations in Hawai'i:
 - [ĀinaVIS:](#)
 - [Methodology](#)
 - [Findings/Results](#)
 - [FAQs](#)
 - [About](#)
 - [O'ahu StewMap](#)
 - [Project Dashboard \(Comprehensive Map Findings\)](#)
 - [O'ahu Social Networks](#)
 - [Data](#)
 - [Guide](#)
 - [FAQs](#)
 - [2019 Survey Results](#)

Kamehameha Schools Data Sources

[Annual Reports](#) (as of April 2026, years 1999-2025 were available)

[Form 990 Tax Filings](#) (via ProPublica, years 2001-2024)

- Schedule I contains names and addresses of community organizations that received grants from Kamehameha Schools

Report on Financial Activities (1 page summary of annual financial activities):

- [2024-2025](#)
- [2022-2023](#)
- [2021-2022](#)
- [2020-2021](#)
- [2019-2020](#)
- [2018-2019](#)

- [2017-2018](#)
- [2016-2017](#)
- [2016-2015](#)
- [2013-2014](#)
- [2012-2013](#)
- [2011-2012](#)
- [2010-2011](#)
- [2009-2010](#)
- [2008-2009](#)
- [2005-2006](#)

Consolidated Financial Statements (comprehensive report on annual financial activities):

- [2022-2023](#)
- [2021-2022](#)
- [2020-2021](#)
- [2019-2020](#)
- [2018-2019](#)
- [2017-2018](#)
- [2016-2017](#)
- [2015-2016](#)
- [2014-2015](#)
- [2013-2014](#)
- [2012-2013](#)